



Plant focus: clematis

The vast range of flower forms and plant sizes make clematis invaluable additions to large or small gardens.

VALUED FOR THEIR VERSATILITY, clematis can be used to dress up arches and pergolas, scramble through trees, and cover walls and fences with climbing stems of colorful flowers. As well as beautiful blooms, many species also sport decorative seedheads and, with careful selection, clematis can decorate the garden almost year round. Clematis comprise a wide variety of species and cultivars. Many summer-flowering forms produce large showy blooms, while plants that perform in spring, late summer, and fall often bear smaller flowers. Most clematis, barring a few shrubby types, are hardy climbers and require support for their twining leaf stems to cling to. Use horizontal wires on walls and fences, or slim stakes to coax them onto trees and shrubs. To produce the best displays, clematis should be pruned annually, and the method you use depends on when they flower. Those that bloom in spring and early summer generally require a light trim, while later-flowering forms are cut back hard.

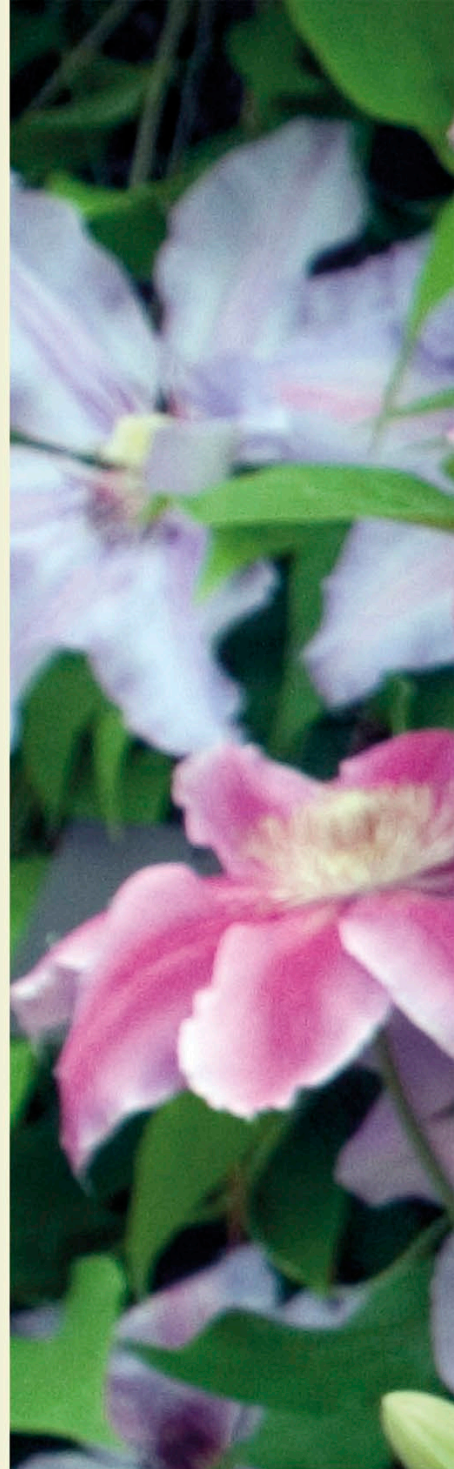
USING CLEMATIS

Cover walls and fences with the flowers and foliage of clematis by fixing horizontal wires or a trellis securely to the surface. Roses and clematis are a classic planting combination for arches and pergolas. Select plants that bloom at the same time for the most colorful display.

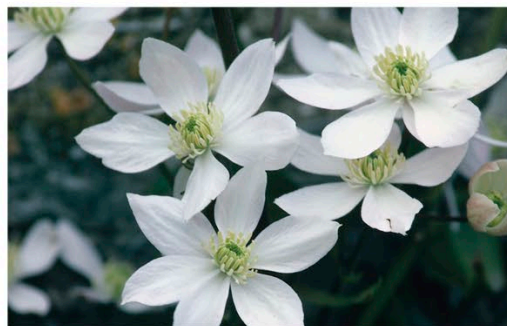


Compact clematis have been specially bred to grow in pots and are the best choice for patio displays. Plant them in a large container and provide a tripod to support their stems.

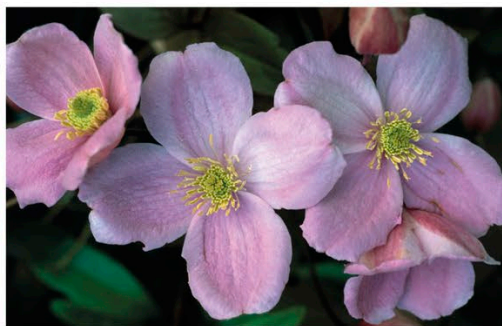
Large early summer-flowering clematis can be combined to decorate walls and fences with blooms, which form richly colored backdrops for beds and borders.



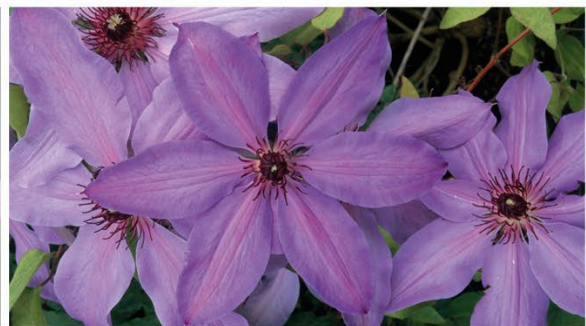
POPULAR CLEMATIS SPECIES



Evergreens The early spring-flowering *C. cirrhosa* and *C. armandii* have evergreen leaves and are not as hardy as deciduous types. Plant them in a sheltered site, away from cold winds.



Spring-flowering forms *C. macropetala* and *C. alpina* fall into this group, with their nodding, bell-shaped flowers, as do forms of the rambling *C. montana* with their star-shaped blooms.



Early-season large-flowered forms These include many popular forms that bear large single and double flowers in a wide range of colors from late spring to midsummer.